

Chapter 72-1: Dream

The woman's slender arms were still wrapped around her waist, as if locked in place. Chu Qingqiu wanted to break free but was afraid of hurting her, so she could only resist using brute force. However, just as she escaped a little, she was forcefully pulled back by Ning Fuyi. After going back and forth twice, she stopped moving.

She trembled as she exhaled, her heartbeat wild and unbearable. She couldn't help but clench her palms to slightly calm the palpitations.

How many years had she endured this? Yet when approaching this little demon again, her heart would still be thrown into chaos.

Clearly she had watched Ning Fuyi grow up, clearly she had always prided herself on being calm and composed, but why was it that every time they got close, she was always the first to lose her composure?

Chu Qingqiu relaxed her strength and no longer struggled to break free. Instead, she allowed herself to be embraced by Ning Fuyi, falling to her side and crashing into her radiated warmth.

The wind scattered the clouds, the bright moon shone, and the tree shadows were mottled. This night the wind rose and clouds drifted peacefully without incident.

Ning Fuyi fell into endless dreams. First, she saw the two trees competing for beauty in her sea of consciousness¹. After not seeing them for a few days, each had grown larger, with roots tangling and penetrating deep into the soil below, and tops reaching the sky and extending into the blue heavens above. The black tree had several fruits that had rotted and split open, from which more branches and leaves had grown, penetrating straight into the earth and taking root.

When she was shocked and reached out to touch those branches and leaves, the scene before her eyes disappeared again. She was standing alone on a hillside with no trees, while below the slope was a ten-li apricot blossom forest².

When the wind blew, the fragrant petals scattered in the wind, falling like a colorful rain of flower petals. Looking from afar on the slope, she could see a woman dancing with a bundle of flower branches in the flower forest, sword qi carrying the petals to form a long dragon that circled around her.

Ning Fuyi held her breath and involuntarily entered the flower forest. Flower petals immediately brushed past her face piece by piece, and the woman's figure came into view.

Like a soaring dragon or dancing snake, like swimming fish and flying birds, her long sleeves flowed gracefully, dancing with the flowers.

Sleeves stained with flower fragrance brushed past her face. After the semi-transparent sleeves left, the woman's face was already close at hand, and the clear fragrance gradually approached. Ning Fuyi suddenly felt her cheeks burning hot.

The woman seemed to be saying something, pulling her hand and placing it at her waist. Ning Fuyi couldn't help but clench her hand tightly, desperately trying to see the woman's appearance clearly. However, that face always seemed to be covered by a mist, making it impossible to see anything, and even the voice was blurred.

The woman came closer and closer. Ning Fuyi opened her eyes wide, but just as their lips were about to touch, she seemed to be suddenly pulled out of the dream by something, opening her eyes with a cold sweat.

Cool wind blew past. She stared in shock at the carved bed post before her eyes, breathing heavily.

With the continuous alternation of inhalation and exhalation, the scenes from the dream also gradually withdrew from her mind thread by thread, leaving only a dense flower forest.

She groaned softly, wanting to use her hand to wipe the sweat from her forehead. However, her right hand moved but had no response. Only then did she notice that there was someone beside her.

Chu Qingqiu also woke up at this moment. When meeting those clear, cold eyes, Ning Fuyi almost failed to breathe in, and subconsciously wanted to get up, but was pulled back to the bed by her own hand.

The bed beneath creaked, and Ning Fuyi blinked, raising her left hand to her heart to prevent that heart from leaping out.

In the past, she hadn't never been this close to Chu Qingqiu. Even during her previous life when she imprisoned Chu Qingqiu, she most loved seeing Chu Qingqiu's humiliated appearance.

But at that time she only had hatred for her, now however...

Finally, she steadied her mind before speaking: "Divine Venerable."

Chu Qingqiu was naturally also flustered and at a loss, but both of them were now pretending to be calm, and Chu Qingqiu had always been better at pretending. So she calmly withdrew the sleeve that had been pressed under Ning Fuyi, turned over and rose. Pieces of flying feathers brushed around her body, and the wrinkled clothes restored their ethereal immortal aura.

"Last night you suffered from severe headaches. I temporarily suppressed your six senses to ease the pain. Who knew that in your severe pain you would hold onto me and not let go, so we spent the whole night until dawn," Chu Qingqiu said.

Ning Fuyi discovered that whether Chu Qingqiu referred to herself as "I" or "this venerable" completely depended on her mood at the moment.

Ning Fuyi struggled to sit up with her numb arm and thanked the Divine Venerable.

"Why haven't you gotten up yet? Is the headache still not reduced?" Chu Qingqiu frowned.

"No," Ning Fuyi pressed her lips together, looked down at her right hand, and smiled. "It's numb."

Chu Qingqiu was speechless for a long moment, then finally turned and paced to the window. The faint morning light illuminated her face, and her black hair showed a glassy luster.

"Did this pain start after you came out of the tiger's den³?" she asked.

Ning Fuyi nodded while getting out of bed.

"I have already asked Jiang Li to come here, and she should arrive soon. The matter of your headache probably needs her examination to know the cause," Chu Qingqiu turned slightly to the side. "Besides the pain, do you have any other feelings? For example, did you see anything?"

Ning Fuyi lowered her eyes and recalled for a good while. In her memory there was only a flower forest and those two towering trees. Since she didn't want to hide anything from Chu Qingqiu anymore, she told her everything.

When she mentioned the flower forest, Chu Qingqiu's fingertips hidden in her sleeves moved slightly, but she didn't say much. However, when she heard about the two trees that had grown larger, her expression became much more serious.

"What did those trees look like?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

"Lush branches and leaves, smooth trunks without scars, heart-shaped leaves. As for the fruits, except for the color, they were no different from plums."

Chu Qingqiu unconsciously pressed her fingertips against the jade bracelet, her expression complex.

"I understand. You should go back first. If the headache recurs, have someone come find me," Chu Qingqiu said.

Ning Fuyi's head no longer hurt, but her heartbeat hadn't completely calmed down. She had long been eager to leave quickly. After hearing her words, she hurriedly quickened her pace and pushed the door open.

After being blown by the cold wind outside for a while, she finally recovered.

She first went to find Rong Jin to inquire about the current situation in the sect, learning that after Elder Pingyao returned to the sect, he had begun secretly investigating whether there were any traces of those demons or demon spies. Her heart felt somewhat at ease.

She also incidentally listened to news about Mei Chengsi⁴, learning that after being knocked unconscious by Elder Pingyao, he was furious and caused a great commotion in the sect. However, since he had never been convincing and had quite few disciples supporting him in the sect, no one paid attention to him. He was even placed under house arrest by Elder Pingyao using some method.

It was called house arrest, but was actually mostly surveillance, since he had repeatedly caused trouble and was most suspicious.

Rong Jin soon went to organize the investigation, so Ning Fuyi bid him farewell and walked toward Zhuguang Pavilion.

As a result, just as she turned a corner on the stone steps, she heard a commotion of chickens flying and dogs jumping. She ran a few quick steps into the courtyard and caught Liu Wenzhu, who almost fell to the ground.

Liu Wenzhu covered her head and turned around. Seeing it was Ning Fuyi, she immediately grabbed her unable to bear it any longer: "Yiyi, please control Ping'an⁵! Ever since it saw Jiuying, it's been like crazy, desperately chasing after Jiuying. Since early morning it's been making Zhuguang Pavilion completely chaotic!"

"Ping'an?" Ning Fuyi looked past her into the courtyard, seeing that all the disciples of Zhuguang Pavilion were crowded under the eaves watching the excitement, people pressed against people, none willing to step out the door.

Chapter 72-2: Dream

The potted plants and ornamental rocks placed in the courtyard had almost all been knocked over, with dust flying everywhere, making Ning Fuyi cough.

Jiuying was holding a white, chubby bundle by the scruff of its neck with one hand, struggling to lift it high so that its four wildly flailing paws wouldn't touch her.

Seeing Ning Fuyi's figure with her peripheral vision, her narrow eyes almost stood upright: "Ning Fuyi! Quickly take this guy away!"

As she spoke, Ping'an stuck out its tongue toward her, seemingly wanting to lick her cheek. Jiuying was immediately horrified, red light flashed in her palm, and she swatted Ping'an fiercely to the ground with her claws, preventing her flower-like jade face from getting saliva on it.

Jiuying lifted her fingertips to brush away the hair that had been messed up on her face. Her golden eyes immediately looked up, and with just one glance, all the disciples in the courtyard shrank back their heads, none daring to say much.

Seeing this, Ning Fuyi hooked her lips, fanned away the scattered dust in front of her, patted Liu Wenzhu's shoulder, walked forward, and clapped her hands toward Ping'an.

Ping'an's tail immediately wagged frantically. In a flash, it broke free from the red light, spread its hooves and ran toward Ning Fuyi. Its heavy body suddenly leaped up and pounced into Ning Fuyi's arms.

Ning Fuyi immediately felt like a stone lion from outside the gate had smashed into her hands. She couldn't help but step back two paces, using all her strength to hold Ping'an while tilting her head to avoid Ping'an's tender little tongue.

"This is your own offspring, how can you still dislike it?" Ning Fuyi raised an eyebrow at Jiuying.

Jiuying tossed her white hair behind her back, cast a seductive sideways glance at Ping'an, turned around, and looked displeased: "It must have recognized the wrong parent. I, Qi Jiuying⁶, am the most beautiful qilin of the qilin clan. Even if it was a poorly developed egg, it couldn't have hatched into such an ugly thing!"

Ping'an twisted its head and barked at Jiuying.

Liu Wenzhu, who had been watching the excitement like Xi Shi holding her heart⁷, heard this and her almond eyes widened: "Ping'an? Is it a qilin?"

"I never said it was a qilin!" Jiuying seemed very unwilling to look at Ping'an, turning her face halfway away, then turning back as if seeing something dirty, filled with grief: "Ugly, it's really too ugly!"

Ping'an whimpered.

Liu Wenzhu looked at Ning Fuyi, then at Ping'an, blinked her eyes, and took Ping'an from Ning Fuyi's hands that could no longer hold steady, finally liberating Ning Fuyi's already aching arms.

"Thank you," Ning Fuyi rubbed her hands and made eye contact with her.

"You just came out of the tiger's den, you must still be tired. I'll help you walk Ping'an," Liu Wenzhu put Ping'an on the ground and clapped her hands at it. Ping'an reluctantly followed behind her and left.

Ning Fuyi walked into the room, and Jiuying glanced at Ping'an's retreating figure, sighed heavily, then swayed her hips and followed behind Ning Fuyi. Seeing Ning Fuyi sit down, she also lifted her skirt and sat beside her.

Jiuying was indeed born with stunning beauty, especially with an excellent figure. Unlike the always neatly dressed immortal sect disciples, her dress not only exposed her waist but also both fragrant shoulders, making a group of female disciples blush.

Jiuying raised half an eyebrow at the disciples crowded in the inner room. There was another commotion over there, and then they scattered like birds and beasts.

"You do attract women's affection, but this is Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. I don't want to be so conspicuous, so restrain yourself somewhat," Ning Fuyi used an ink stick to tap twice on her exposed, well-proportioned shoulders.

"Not just attracting women's affection - during those few months when I was empress, all the men and women I summoned were deeply infatuated with me," Jiuying smiled with pursed lips.

"Besides, what use is it for you not to be conspicuous? Before dawn today, many disciples had already come to the door, wanting to see with their own eyes what this ancient divine beast looked like."

Ning Fuyi sighed helplessly, said no more, and lowered her head to grind ink.

"Now that I'm not a demon beast, living isn't bad either. I can smell flowers and see scenery," Jiuying put her two long legs on the long bench, crossed her arms on the long table, and immediately had the bearing of a qilin. "You shouldn't always stay cooped up in these mountains either. When you go out for training or something, let me see what the current landscape has become."

Ning Fuyi reasonably suspected that this divine beast had been locked up for tens of thousands of years and had gone stir-crazy, talking endlessly.

"I'm not restraining you. You can go out and play," Ning Fuyi pointed toward the foot of the mountain.

"Listen, girl," Jiuying glared at her with her eyes. "If I could leave, I would have left long ago. If it weren't for seeing that your sea of consciousness is unstable, who would want to stay beside a yellow-haired girl like you?"

"My sea of consciousness is unstable?" Ning Fuyi's brush paused.

"Mm," Jiuying lazily fiddled with the brush stand. "I don't know why, but from the moment your body was reshaped, your sea of consciousness has been constantly chaotic. I originally wanted to go in and take a look, but it seems some force is blocking me from entering, so I couldn't see."

"But you probably won't die anytime soon, so don't panic," Jiuying smiled. "If you die, I'll be free, so I'm not panicking either."

Ning Fuyi suddenly felt that forming a contract with her might not necessarily be a good thing.

She no longer paid attention to the bored Jiuying, lowered her head to write some names on paper, then crossed them out one by one.

From the moment she was reborn, she had suffered several "accidents": falling into Ghost Eye, the catastrophe at Zhaoshan Mountain, and falling into the tiger's den. Except for the first time, the demon clan people had appeared in all the other incidents.

She had long felt something was wrong about the Ghost Eye incident, but at the time she hadn't noticed anything, and when she asked other disciples, they said they hadn't seen anything. Unable to find any clues, she hadn't dwelled on it much.

Now thinking carefully, these incidents seemed to be connected. Someone had been trying to kill her from the beginning. That person was hidden beside her, always scheming in secret and not daring to appear openly. They must still be wary of the immortal sect's protection and fearful of Chu Qingqiu.

There was no such person in her previous life, nor had so many accidents occurred. Could it be that this person only wanted to kill her in this lifetime?

Was she not the only one who had been reborn?

Ning Fuyi crossed out those names one by one. Finally, some remained. She fell into deep thought, suddenly recalling the scene she had seen in the forest on the day Li Chao'an was bewitched.

The little flower fairy that had been struck to ash by lightning, and the withered vines on the ground.

Her fingertips trembled slightly for a moment. She raised her hand to circle the last name she had written, her heart feeling somewhat heavy.

She waved her hand to burn the paper covered with names, stood up to go find Chu Qingqiu. But just as she stood up, the severe pain from last night found her again. The pain made sweat pour out like a fountain, instantly soaking her entire body.

She gripped the table board tightly, her body involuntarily falling to one side. Jiuying, who had almost fallen asleep nearby, suddenly woke up and saw the situation, her expression turning cold.

Without saying a word, she extended her hand to summon red light, which continuously flowed into Ning Fuyi's forehead.

Ning Fuyi bent over in pain and muttered a few words deliriously, then her body went limp and was caught by Jiuying's quick reflexes. She withdrew the red light and anxiously patted Ning Fuyi's face with her hand: "Ning Fuyi! Ning Fuyi!"

Seeing that Ning Fuyi wasn't responding, she clicked her tongue with anger, bent down to carry Ning Fuyi horizontally, and quickly walked out the door to find someone.

Just as she was about to take to the clouds, someone descended from the sky, landing gracefully. Looking up, it was Chu Qingqiu holding white bone with an unpleasant expression.

Footnotes:

¹ **Sea of consciousness (识海)** - In cultivation novels, this refers to the spiritual space within a cultivator's mind where their soul and spiritual power reside.

² **Ten-li apricot blossom forest (十里杏花林)** - A vast forest of apricot trees in bloom; "li" is a Chinese unit of distance (approximately 0.5 km), so this refers to a forest stretching for about 5 kilometers.

³ **Tiger's den (虎穴)** - Refers to the dangerous place Ning Fuyi recently escaped from, literally meaning a place of extreme danger.

⁴ **Mei Chengsi (梅承嗣)** - A character in the story, likely an elder or authority figure in the sect who has been causing problems.

⁵ **Ping'an (平安)** - Literally means "peace/safety," this is the name of what appears to be a pet or spirit companion that has been causing chaos.

⁶ **Qi Jiuying (麒九婴)** - The character's full name, where "Qi" refers to qilin and "Jiuying" is her personal name.

⁷ **Xi Shi holding her heart (西子捧心)** - A Chinese idiom referring to a famous beauty from ancient times who would hold her chest when feeling unwell, creating a particularly charming appearance. Used here to describe someone watching drama with great interest.